

Shadow Skin

Prologue

The burn of transforming shadow skin faded, allowing the switcher to think with a clear head. Something was wrong. In the air he'd felt clumsy . . . heavy. Now, beneath the waves, he felt as though he owned the ocean and everything in it. He felt mighty . . . menacing . . . he felt like a predator. The intensity of the emotions was disturbing. It took the switcher a moment to get them under control. This was definitely not the form he'd prepared for. Should he play it safe and abandon the visit? No. This was a simple vault. So simple he'd even left the hexagon open. He'd been inside it many times before without incident. There was no point overreacting. Besides, he had a flair for learning new forms . . . and there was something instantly addictive about this one.

The switcher gave his tail its first flick. A conical nose and solid, torpedo-shaped body powered forward. Seawater rushed through his nostrils, hitting folds of tissue that contained special smell detecting cells. His mind exploded with images. It was like sniffing the water as he swam. Strangely, the ocean smelled of steel, frost and age. It was salty too, with traces of dirt and decay. The switcher chuckled to himself. The outside only ever smelt of warm, moist clay. This vault was sensory overload. He was a starving man diving into a banquet.

He made gentle adjustments to his dorsal and pectoral fins, discovering how they kept him level and on course – just like the rudders and wings on an aeroplane. As he turned into the current, tiny electrical impulses suddenly peppered his nose. They ebbed and flowed like the ocean itself, strong then faint, clear then murky. Soothed by the natural movement of the water, the switcher remained stationary for just a moment. His

environment exuded a gentle power that was both mesmerising and unnerving. The ocean breathed in and out, forcing this whole underwater world to swing to the same hypnotic rhythm. It calmed him. And yet, flowing through the near silent shades of blue, was an ominous undercurrent of dread. Instinct made the switcher move. Something about this form. He could never rest. He had to stay active, keep moving. Another flick of his tail drove him deeper.

High above the ocean, the evening sky was ablaze with splashes of violent colour. Rays of light penetrated the water, refracting and reflecting into streaks of light and dark. They reached beneath the waves, feeling for the place where the boy lay in wait. When they found him, they fell across his back like sinewy black fingers, undulating slowly, as though Death himself were caressing a beloved, bloodthirsty pet.

Carcharodon Carcharias. The boy's scientific name suddenly came to him. That's how it seemed to work in this place. The longer he was here, the more he just 'knew' – a side effect that the switcher certainly wasn't aware of. Other skills had been developing too. If he concentrated, he could add objects, move them around or change their colour . . . and then there was his biggest surprise for the switcher. He smiled his relentless, jagged smile. *Carcharodon Carcharias*. He was known by other names too, 'White Pointer', and the one that thrilled him most, 'White Death'. He would be living up to that name soon.

Mastering this place had become an obsession, but now a single thought pecked at the boy's mind – could he master the shadow speak that had brought him here? First things first. Escape. It wouldn't be long now. The switcher had already entered the ocean. The boy looked around. There needed to be more movement, more distractions. As his thoughts took shape, they imposed themselves on his surroundings. Electrical impulses bombarded the sensory organs on his nose. Perfect. Generated by beating hearts and gill actions, they were impulses typical of a large shoal of

panicking fish. Slowly, more powerful, rhythmic pulses reached him through the water. They signified a group of larger fish . . . dolphins.

The dolphins came into view, arcing up and down, in and out of the ocean. Living silver needles, stitching sea to burning sky. They were moving in on the shoal of herring, clicking signals to each other, harrying, organising. With supreme skill, the dolphins began moulding the fish into one tight, black mass beneath the blue water. They too, were preparing for a feast.

Like an invitation, the electrical impulses tickled the switcher's snout again. He steered through the water, all the time receiving messages from his body's senses: shift slightly left; move a fraction deeper. It didn't take him long to locate the source. And the sight was startling. Before him was a towering tornado of life. Thousands of darting, shimmering fish twisting and turning as one. Each fish was like a tiny mirror, its scales giving off flashes of light as it darted left and right. His new senses enabled him to distinguish between the healthy and the weak, the old and the young. It was incredible. Just the movement, the electrical aura, the *feel* of each fish provided him with a wealth of information. The urge to chase them was overwhelming. With a tingle of anticipation, the switcher picked out a stray herring from the edge of the group and zoomed after it. In the blink of an eye the fish was at his mercy. He could have opened his jaws and devoured it easily. Instead, he gently nosed it aside and went after another. The joy he felt was almost unbearable. Such speed, agility and power . . . such a feeling of invincibility. He knew now what he had become. He was the result of hundreds of millions of years of evolution – and a prime example of Mother Nature's evil streak. Two words came to his mind, both from Greek – *carcharos*, meaning 'ragged', and *odon* meaning 'tooth'. He was *Carcharodon Carcharias* – The Great White Shark.

Without warning, the shoal of herring split. Two black, soulless eyes loomed through the kaleidoscopic tunnel of shining scales. The eyes sped

towards him, rolling back in their sockets, bottomless black replaced by ghostly white. Too late, realisation dawned on the switcher – the boy! The boy who never apologised. The boy who had so far refused to change his ways . . . he had taken the form of a Great White shark too!

The impact was ferocious. Three thousand razor sharp teeth hit their mark, just below the switcher's five gill slits. Triangular daggers did their job, shredding leathery grey and white skin.

A split second of shock – then the switcher whipped his body away to avoid further punishment. As he did so, blood flowed from his side like red slipstream from an undersea plane. Thoughts filled his head. *How had this happened? Only switchers had control of these vaults! The boy had been left here in the form of a harmless little sand eel, to be badgered and bullied by bigger fish. It was supposed to teach him a lesson – give him a taste of his own medicine. How had the boy transformed from a small eel to a Great White shark?* The switcher cursed his complacency. He had known something was wrong the moment he entered the vault. Take no risks. That had been drummed into him from the very beginning. He should have turned back. Instead he had let himself be seduced by this extraordinary new form. And now he was under no illusion: he was in mortal danger. He needed to end this.

The switcher opened and closed his massive jaws, testing his armoury. Three rows of deadly, serrated teeth; the first two rows ready to rip apart chunks of flesh – teeth in the third row ready to move forward in case any in the front rows broke off. Yes, he was a powerful creature, but the bite from the boy had done terrible damage. And the dangers were multiplying. Sharks could smell a single drop of blood from a mile away. If his blood attracted other Great Whites, he would be the target of a savage feeding frenzy. He didn't have much time. His only form of defence was attack. Kill or be killed.

For the first time the switcher logged his position. He was about a metre below the waves with no land in sight. Above him the dissolving sun

appeared to wobble and stretch into the darkening sky, like a little orange tongue flicking out, trying to snatch a taste of the stars. Something else caught his eye - a slight distortion, just below the orange tongue. Was it the vault door? He let his eyes relax and looked again. Yes! There it was – a faint, but definite hexagonal outline. Maybe there was no need for this fight to continue. The switcher peered into the murky depths, anticipating a second attack from the boy. A flash of grey and white below him - the switcher twisted sideways, skilfully avoiding the strike.

At first the boy didn't realise he'd missed. The protective white cover on his eyes blinded him during that vital last second. Overcome by bloodlust, he continued to thrust upwards, malicious and malevolent. He smashed through the surface of the ocean, launching himself into fresh air and dying light. Water exploded outwards like bubbling white shrapnel, consuming the surrounding waves. His body thrashed about in mid-air, pink and bloodied jaws gnashing instinctively. Light played with the fine spray across his exposed white underside, adorning his gyrating belly with sparkling, blood red diamonds.

Gravity soon ended the macabre dance and, as he fell back towards the ocean, the boy uncovered his eyes. What he saw made his heart pump faster. He forgot all about the fight. It was there. The vault door . . . *the way home!* He could almost smell the fresh air, taste the food . . . chocolate, beef burgers, ice cream . . . all the things he could do when he got back! Make other children cry. That's what he'd missed most of all.

After avoiding the boy's attack, the switcher had moved to deep water. He was at the base of the shoal. Around him, dolphins were releasing bubbles from their blowholes. The bubbles were keeping the herring confused and tightly packed. Most important of all, they were keeping him hidden. From behind his screen the switcher saw the boy re-enter the ocean. Now was the perfect time to strike. In a classic shark attack, he angled his

body upwards and launched himself at the boy's silhouette.

The boy scolded himself. Seeing the vault door had been a distraction. If he hadn't smelt the blood oozing from the switcher's wound, he may have missed the attack. Confident that he was both the stronger and faster of the two sharks, he decided to meet the charge head on. The switcher was already badly injured. He couldn't possibly survive a second clash.

With their mouths set in a natural hideous grin, the two primeval monsters drew closer. Neither one slowing, neither one with the slightest intention of pulling out. They could see each other with frightening clarity, see the intent in the other's black, pitiless eyes. The boy put extra energy into his attack, thrusting his tail from side to side, powering his vicious teeth forwards. He focused hard on his target, thrilled that they had passed the point of no return. Impact was only a second away . . . *victory only a second away . . . home only a . . .* THUD! Something hammered into the boy's side. His body shuddered as he was rammed sideways through the water. Shock and pain stunned him into stillness. He willed his mighty caudal fin to power him out of trouble, but it wouldn't respond. He was paralysed. The only parts of his shark body still working were his eyes. Through them he could see the perpetrator of the attack. It was a large male dolphin. One of the very dolphins that he'd brought in to distract the switcher. Inside the boy couldn't help but smile. He'd underestimated his opponent – a true schoolboy error. The switcher had infinitely superior shadow skills, and he'd shown it by influencing a creature that he hadn't even created.

The boy's huge hulk drifted with the current. It was over. He was a sitting duck.

The switcher circled the boy once, nature's most efficient hunter with his prey at his mercy. Age-old instincts of the Great White urged him to kill his quarry – tear the boy to pieces, rip away chunks of flesh . . . feast . . . stain the ocean red. He circled the boy once more, moved lower . . . and then

thundered in. His teeth plunged into the boy's side, leaving a ring of puncture wounds around the gill slits. And that was all. He had no wish to kill the boy, only to slow him down and stop this madness. The switcher turned away. The only thing that mattered was being the first to reach the vault door. Things were going badly wrong in the shadow vaults. The boy being able to change his own form was inexplicable . . . unbelievable. And for the switcher it was the final straw. Shadow vaults could no longer be trusted. They could never be used again.

The boy looked on, helpless. But the sight of the switcher's tail merging with the blue-green gloom put fire in his belly. That switcher could have. . . *should* have finished him off. This fight wasn't over yet. Not by a long way. The boy concentrated hard, willing himself to move forward. Nothing. Frustration built to a blinding fury. A series of forced, spasmodic twitches shifted his body around. The effort sapped him, but he no longer felt set in concrete. Each flick of his tail loosened his body and built his speed. Ignoring the pain from the bite, the boy focused on the switcher. No longer a tail in the distance. It was now an out and out race to the vault door.

The switcher rose towards the surface, slowing slightly, getting his bearings. The beginnings of a storm hampered visibility, but the vault door wasn't far now. His dorsal fin sliced through a slick of his own blood as he re-submerged. He was weakening. But he had to be out first. The boy could not be allowed to leave. He hadn't learnt his lesson - hadn't been *fixed*. The switcher glanced behind, hoping he had built up a sufficient lead. To his dismay, he saw the boy closing fast.

Already silt, weed and sand had been stirred from the ocean floor. The water had transformed into an angry, heaving mass of blue-green soup. Waves shot up like watery stalagmites, jabbing and stabbing at the sky. Through it all, the two sharks surged on. Their fins, now almost level, cut an unerring path towards the vault door. The switcher prayed to the mighty

Orisha, asking that he be the one to make it through first. He vowed to continue his work in a different way if he did.

Next to him the boy also made a vow. He vowed to do whatever it took to get out of this shadow vault . . . this shadow skin. And, if his own body wasn't waiting for him in the real world . . . he would steal the switcher's!

Like synchronised swimmers, they drove forward side by side. Both with huge bite marks in their sides, both leaving a ribbon of blood trailing behind them.

The sharks submerged beneath the raging waves. Then, in perfect unison, they veered steeply upwards. With every last ounce of strength that remained in their shark bodies, the switcher and the boy launched themselves out of the water towards the shimmering vault door. Even in mid-air they jostled and thrashed about, both desperate to reach the exit first. There could be only one winner. Only one of them could make it through.

And only one of them did.

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